vice versa. It was such a grab bag of a novel, and yet, if you tried to think of it without its smallest part, you saw it was a finely-wrought jigsaw.

3.Amitav Ghosh
The Hungry Tide (2004)
Yes, I know you have other older books in mind. But this one is so liquid with stories that you cannot help going down again for more, coming up again with some other strange, wriggling story. Set in the Sundarbans, that forest of water, that barometer of the weather, that source of gods and demons and disaster, it begins with a quest. Piyali looks for dolphins in the manner of a scientist and must contend with the very different Kanai and the boatman Fakir. In a way, this novel also foretells Ghosh's commitment to climate change and the disasters of the Anthropocene.

4. Kiran Nagarkar
Cuckold (1997)
Again, everyone's favourite may be *Raavan & Eddie,* but this one has my heart. Nagarkar has told the story of his conversion often, the dark ride in a freezing Delhi auto when the cuckold demands that his story be told. The Rana who has been cuckolded by the Blue Divinity is one of the most convincing historical characters I have ever read. There is a wonderful set piece about trying to win battles by running away to fight another day. (Ranchhoddas would approve.) And when all else fails, may a man not woo his wife by painting himself blue?

5. Manju Kapur
Home (2006)
We are a nation of families. Family defines who we are for others; it seeks to define who we are too. Manju Kapur is one of the great archivists of the upper-class upper-caste North Indian family. In *Home*, she sets out her pieces with the care of a chessplayer and then she watches as they head towards the inevitable explosion occasioned by the meeting of an irresistible force (headstrong young women) and immoveable objects (patriarchal old men).

6. Anita Desai
In Custody (1984)
I think we were reminded of how much we loved Urdu, we were also reminded of how much savagery had been shown to it and how much more we loved it as it raised its tattered self and put on a proud show at the *mehfil* of languages. To write in English, a language that works best with understatement, about Urdu, a language that throws out its arms to embrace emotion, is to court disaster. It takes a daring novelist to do that and Anita Desai, blessed with German and English and Gujarati and Hindi, pulled it off with elan.

7. Arundhati Roy
The God of Small Things (1997)
Ayemenem is on every Indian's literary map. It is markedly different from earlier idyllic south Indian spaces because it is richly green, yes, it is beautiful yes, and it is also veined by casteism and there is danger lurking for two Syrian Christian children with huge eyes from a vendor of sweet drinks. This is not about what happens but about the texture of the writing. That is moss, dank, moist, rich and unforgettable.

8. Githa Hariharan
When Dreams Travel (1999)
No one remembers their first encounter with the thousand-and-one nights, which ought, by now, to be a common noun. I remember buying a 17-volume edition when I was 14 and only finding the time to read it when the pandemic made long luscious hours of reading possible. This is a beautifully textured retelling of that world.

9. Amruta Patil
Kari (2008)
It is difficult to say how important *Kari* was for generations of women readers. Amruta Patil's graphic novel was powerful, but there was something eerie about it too, as if under the surface of the largely black-and-white graphics, there ran a river of blood. It was also a sexy book and it introduced us to another kind of woman, a complete break from the stereotypes of femininity.

10. I. Allan Sealy
The Everest Hotel (1988)
I had not seen the High Himalaya when I was reading *The Everest Hotel,* but I could see almost all of the novel in my mind's eye. Almost all the characters seemed to have a story. The idea of a hotel—enshrined in our collective consciousness as a locus of license—turned into a haven of last resort run by nuns—terrifying, powerful figures as the renunciate is ever more potent a figure than a potentate—was strangely beautiful and each character that crossed your line of sight was different.

